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GRAPHIC: TATAS AT THE CROSSROADS *PG 14*



RED FLAG Russia remains India's top crude supplier

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INDIA BACK IN CRUDE CROSSFIRE

The US Senate's Russia sanctions bill, carrying the threat of 100 per cent tariffs, has cast a fresh shadow over India's oil strategy and trade negotiations

By M.G. ARUN

THE UNITED STATES HAS ONCE AGAIN RAISED THE SPECTRE OF SANCTIONS over India's purchases of Russian crude oil, injecting fresh uncertainty into both India's energy strategy and its evolving trade ties with Washington. When the US House of Representatives reconvenes on August 31, it is expected to take up the bipartisan Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, which seeks to empower President Donald Trump to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on the five largest buyers of Russian oil and gas—India, China, Azerbaijan, Hungary and Slovakia. The bill secured approval in the Senate—the upper house—in the first week of August. Even if it becomes law, the decision to enforce the tariffs would remain at Trump's discretion.

For New Delhi, the timing is awkward. India and the US are still negotiating a broader trade pact, and the new sanctions threat has reopened questions about whether Russian crude could become a bargaining chip in a relationship that remains complicated.